

**LOSING SHINE** PM Modi and CM Yogi Adityanath at a roadshow in Varanasi, May 13

**The BJP think-tank will now have to ascertain how the state showed a very different voting pattern compared to the rest of the heartland**

(BSP). The Dalit vote for the Yadav party became the story of 2024.

The BJP's ticket distribution, on the other hand, got flak even from the party's inner circle. The top leadership's decision to field 47 sitting MPs spiked the anti-incumbency vote. Also, unlike in 2019, it was the Congress-SP combine that succeeded in setting the narrative—that too around bruising issues like unemployment, feelings around it exacerbated by paper leaks, all-round inflation and the sense of the Constitution being in crisis. The BJP had no effective counter to these.

The party's strategic allies in eastern UP, caste-based outfits like the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) and the Nishad Party, also failed to deliver. Voters in the region seemed to be fed up with the OBC and Dalit sub-segment loyalty narratives. The BJP think-tank has plenty to chew on over how UP led a heartland departure from its narratives, even if states like Madhya Pradesh held firm.

UP-based political analyst Dr Shilp Shikha Singh says, "Losing in Faizabad sent out a statement—that the communal appeal has limits. And anyway, it works best with a negative narrative. Building a temple is a positive development, it won't build communal momentum." She also cites the significance of the Dalit vote swing towards INDIA, fuelled by a threat perception around the constitutional architecture of reservations.

## ANYONE SEEN MAYAWATI?

The decimation of the BSP is also a story of this election. The party of the Dalits failed to open its account, and its vote share fell to single digits—9.4 per cent, a drop of three percentage points even from the 2022 assembly election. The impression that the party was the BJP's B-team, even if an unwilling one, fostered a new phenomenon: the Jatavs, who make up over 50 per cent of the Dalit population in UP and have long been faithful to the BSP, drifted towards whoever they felt was their best succour: the Congress, SP and, in Nagina, the Azad Bhim Party. Chandrashekhar's win in his debut election gives him a toehold in Dalit politics, as a long-term alternative to Mayawati.

Meanwhile, CM Yogi Adityanath will have to take part of the blame for the drastic reverses in his state. But since there is already some anger among the Rajputs at him being 'sidelined', the top leadership is unlikely to risk removing Yogi and stoking the flames further. A big challenge for the CM going forward will be how to play his cards in the state's caste politics as also in terms of the economy. Sources close to Yogi say the focus will now be on job generation and getting investments in UP. How that pans out will be crucial to the future of UP politics, for one factor that went unambiguously in the INDIA bloc's favour cuts across caste and community: the youth vote.

Question paper leaks and the uncertainty of the short-tenure Agnipath scheme contributed a lot to the disenchantment among this demographic. The two issues got a lot of traction during the campaigns of two young SP candidates—Pushpendra Saroj, 25, in Kaushambi and Priya Saroj, 25, in Machhlishehar. The two are now MPs and bear the responsibility of being part of a second-line leadership for the SP. The young leaders, though, credit party president Akhilesh for their victories. The 50-year old former chief minister of UP is now basking in the kudos from supporters and well-wishers. As one veteran put it, the SP chief has delivered a "*dhobi pachhad*" (a wrestling move where an unsuspecting rival is lifted off his feet and thrown on his back) on the BJP worthy of his late father, SP founder, former CM and *kushti* enthusiast Mulayam Singh Yadav. ■